

“Our Sacred Space”: Governance of Reentry at Georgetown’s Prisons and Justice Initiative

M.A. capstone | Georgetown University | 59 pages

A single-case study of how a mission-driven reentry organization navigates the rules, gaps, and tradeoffs created by a fragmented public system.

QUESTION AND APPROACH

The study asks whether frontline reentry practices interrupt, soften, or reproduce punitive governance. Evidence includes nine recorded semi-structured interviews, fifteen weekly field journals, participant observation, and document analysis gathered during a six-month practicum. The design uses consent-based attribution and anonymization where appropriate, triangulation, an explicit positionality analysis, and no causal claims.

CONTRIBUTION

The paper develops a three-regime framework for organizational discretion: domains an intermediary controls; domains that govern through it; and gatekeeping rules it authors itself. It argues that the connective work of translation—interpreting rules, absorbing administrative burden, and linking disconnected institutions—is a form of governance, even when its most important outcomes are difficult to observe.

SELECTED TAKEAWAYS

- PJI can interrupt punitive logic where it controls admissions, curriculum, classrooms, and its own building; it can only mediate many external rules.
- Relational judgment is a core operating capacity. The paper recommends selective structure: scenario-based onboarding, clear escalation paths, visible ownership of shared functions, and periodic feedback.
- For the broader field, provider access before release, education-specific reentry supports, shared outcome definitions, and better public coordination are necessary complements to high-quality intermediary work.

SKILLS DEMONSTRATED

- Qualitative research design, interviewing, participant observation, thematic analysis, and source triangulation
- Institutional analysis, implementation-focused recommendations, long-form writing, and ethical handling of sensitive evidence

Portfolio note: The full paper contains interview and internal organizational material and is not posted publicly. To request the full paper when appropriate, contact Caleb at johnston.caleb325@gmail.com.